order to supply the country's needs and to encourage distant people to come. [5]

While Zheng He's voyages are most well known and written about, Chinese junks were ubiquitous, though smaller, on the routes to other ports on the Indian coast. The ports of Chittagong and Tamluk on the Bengal coast were extensively involved in trade with South-East Asia and China, and the Bengal Sultanate became prosperous from this trade. On one of Zheng He's voyages, another eunuch mariner accompanying him, Hou Xian, sailed to Chittagong, from where he travelled to the capital Sonargaon. The Bengal ruler at the time, Ghiyasuddin, sent a diplomatic mission to China in 1408 CE . Cambay on the Gujarat coast was frequently visited by Chinese vessels. Yongle sent several naval missions under other eunuch admirals, though these were not as grand as the Zheng He voyages.

He also sent a large number of diplomatic missions to China's land neighbours, including Tibet and the polities in Central Asia. These were also led by eunuch officers serving in Yongle's palace bureaucracy. For example, Hou Xian led several missions to Tibet between 1403 and 1427. These may have been aimed at breaking the Mongol connection with Tibet carried over from the previous Yuan dynasty, which could threaten the Ming empire. Unfortunately, there are no extant records of the missions to Tibet. Hou Xian was also sent on missions to South-East Asia and travelled on Zheng He's ships on the second and third voyages. Hou Tong, another eunuch official, led nine missions into the Mongolian region to win allies against the Mongols who threatened north China. We are left with a picture of intense diplomatic activity undertaken by Yongle, engaging with countries in China's neighbourhood and beyond. This is quite unprecedented in Chinese history but proved to be a brief phase, giving way to an extended period of relative isolation that persisted until maritime power began to be regarded as an indispensable component of national power by the PRC during the first decade of the current millennium.

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To return to Admiral Zheng He's naval expeditions, which are worth describing in some detail.